Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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Abstract

oindent Sociologists have long debated the nature of "good" and "bad" taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies BERTopic to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions. I identify distinct cultural models for "good taste" (e.g., Subjectivity, Aesthetics, Style) and "bad taste" (e.g., Dislike, Poor Choices, Poor Manners). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, moralized cultural models are associated with a heightened propensity to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of "good" and "bad" taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by three primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define "good taste" and "bad taste"?
2. How do cultural models of good taste relate to cultural models of bad taste? Are they structurally coupled into broader cultural logics?
3. How do these taste cultural models map onto specific cultural domains (e.g., beer, classical music, wrestling)?

3 Methods

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter "documents"), I used **BERTopic**. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., "good," "bad," "taste," "don't") were removed from each document because these words—mostly paraphrasing the original question—were overwhelmingly common across documents and thus did little to differentiate them. We also remove common English stop words from each document (e.g., the, it, is, do, etc.). The algorithm was optimized for each of the two text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring. Finally, cross-tabulations and domain-distinction Likert scale heatmaps were generated to examine the coherence of these classifications.

4 Results

4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through eight distinct schemas, including *Dislike/Subjective*, *Poor Choices*, *Tacky/Loud*, *Low-Brow Media*, *Ugly Style*, *Low Quality*, *Immoral Art*, and *Poor Manners*.

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	108	Taste Good Like Person	taste, good, like, person, things, think, people, say, mean,...
1	58	Like Things Choices Art	like, things, choices, art, shows, good, appreciate, appeali...
2	16	Means Like Good People	means, like, good, people, interact, services, style, look, ...

Table 1: Good Taste Def Summary

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	61	Bad Taste Things Person	bad, taste, things, person, means, think, people, say, good,...
1	53	Like Things Choices Just	like, things, choices, just, think, care, maybe, good, gaudy...
2	19	Person Loud Sense Colors	person, loud, sense, colors, boo, bold, drama, character, qu...
3	15	Music Movies Enjoy Shows	music, movies, enjoy, shows, bad, watch, taste, say, media, ...
4	14	Colors Look Bad Ugly	colors, look, bad, ugly, clothing, taste, color, style, pers...
5	11	Means Usually Like Quality	means, usually, like, quality, acceptable, racist, horrible,...
6	9	Art Opinions Immoral Value	art, opinions, immoral, value, kitsch, artists, behaving, ai...
7	8	Poor Violence Manner Humor	poor, violence, manner, humor, action, disrespectful, amused...

Table 2: Bad Taste Def Summary

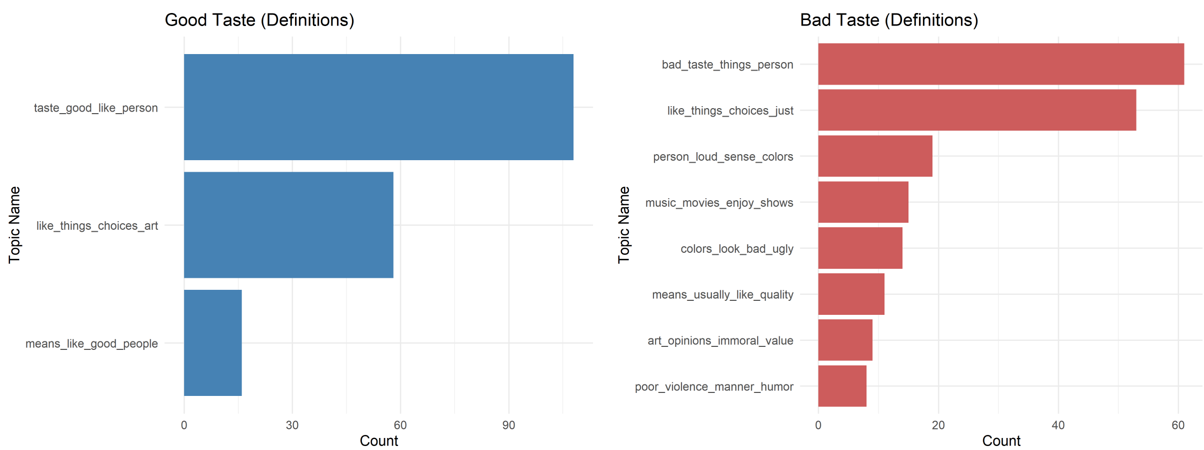


Figure 1: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

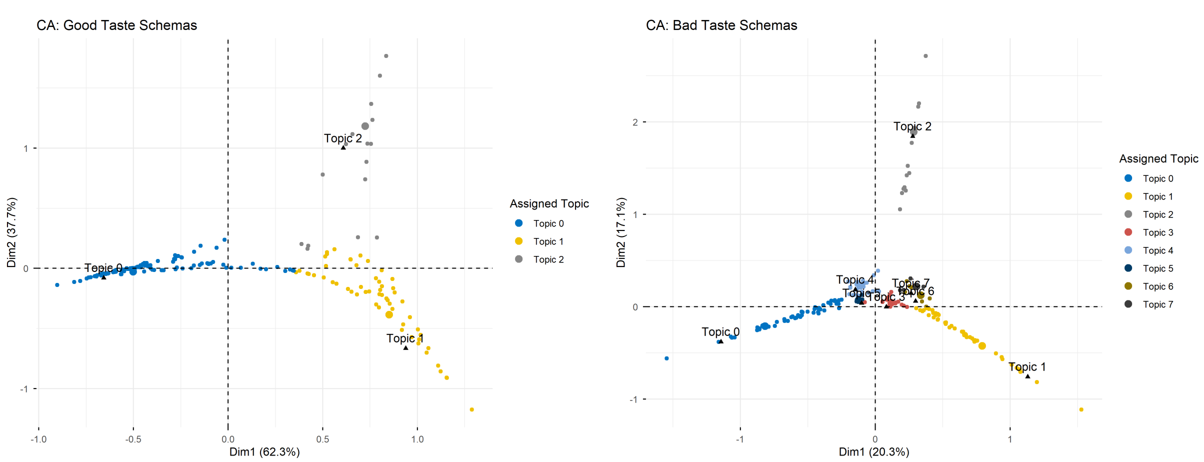
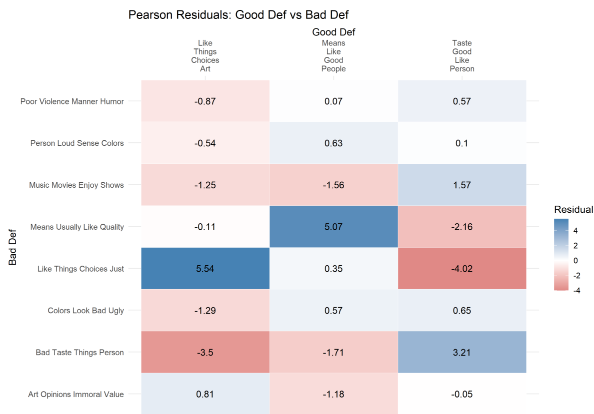


Figure 2: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Schemas (Definitions)

4.2 Cross-Schema Cultural Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent "logics," I cross-tabulated respondents' primary cultural models across the two questions. The associations are highly significant. For instance, a respondent's definition of Good Taste strongly predicts their definition of Bad Taste ($\chi^2 = 115.52, p < 0.001$). Individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity overwhelmingly define bad taste simply as subjective dislike.



4.3 Demographics

To examine whether cultural taste schemas are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents' primary topic schema (across both models) using their Age, Gender, Education, and Political Orientation. The Wald χ^2 tests are presented below.

Model	Predictor	Wald χ^2	Df	p-value
Good Taste Def	Age	3.84	2	0.1464
Good Taste Def	Gender	0.53	2	0.7669
Good Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	0.94	2	0.6253
Good Taste Def	Political	2.51	2	0.2847
Bad Taste Def	Age	12.88	7	0.0750
Bad Taste Def	Gender	2.34	7	0.9384
Bad Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	4.68	7	0.6991
Bad Taste Def	Political	7.31	7	0.3972

Table 3: Multinomial Logistic Regression Wald Tests for Topic Predictors

4.4 Domain Distinction PCA and ANOVA

To analyze respondents' propensity to draw cultural boundaries across domains without testing 19 individual domains simultaneously, I conducted a Principal Component Analysis (PCA) on the distinction ratings. The first dimension captures a general propensity to draw distinctions across all domains (as all variables load positively). The subsequent dimensions capture domain-specific clusters (e.g., separating traditional high-brow arts from pop culture or recreational activities).

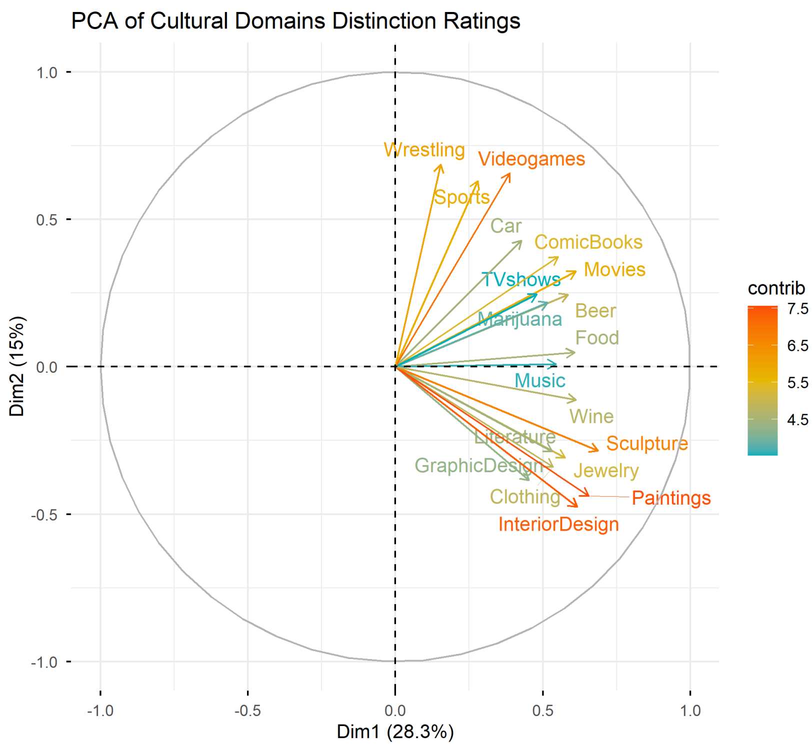


Figure 3: Correlation Circle of Distinction Domains with Principal Components

I extracted the individual respondent scores for the first three PCA dimensions and ran One-Way ANOVAs to test whether mean scores differ significantly depending on the respondent's topic schema assignment. The results demonstrate how different schemas of taste correspond to distinct configurations of cultural boundary-drawing.

Dimension	Good Taste Def	Bad Taste Def
Dim1	1.60 (0.205)	0.20 (0.985)
Dim2	0.82 (0.443)	2.12 (0.044)*
Dim3	2.09 (0.126)	1.41 (0.204)

$^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$

Table 4: ANOVA Results: Mean Differences in PCA Dimensions of Distinction Ratings by Topic Schema.

4.5 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it “makes sense” to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the schema, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

Domain	Good Taste Def F (p_{adj})	Bad Taste Def F (p_{adj})
Beer	2.46 (0.372)	0.60 (0.993)
Car	0.67 (0.673)	1.26 (0.993)
Clothing	2.93 (0.372)	0.86 (0.993)
ComicBooks	2.29 (0.372)	0.16 (0.993)
Food	2.03 (0.372)	0.41 (0.993)
GraphicDesign	1.07 (0.547)	0.30 (0.993)
InteriorDesign	0.57 (0.673)	0.74 (0.993)
Jewelry	0.72 (0.673)	0.55 (0.993)
Literature	0.03 (0.974)	2.28 (0.322)
Marijuana	2.40 (0.372)	1.24 (0.993)
Movies	1.30 (0.480)	0.64 (0.993)
Music	1.67 (0.424)	0.71 (0.993)
Paintings	0.28 (0.843)	0.42 (0.993)
Sculpture	0.18 (0.885)	1.06 (0.993)
Sports	0.59 (0.673)	1.50 (0.993)
TVshows	2.88 (0.372)	0.60 (0.993)
Videogames	2.11 (0.372)	0.72 (0.993)
Wine	1.63 (0.424)	0.60 (0.993)
Wrestling	1.52 (0.425)	6.10^{***} (0.000)

$^{*}p < 0.05$;** $p < 0.01$;*** $p < 0.001$ (Benjamini-Hochberg FDR corrected)

Table 5: One-Way ANOVA Results: Mean Differences in Domain Distinction Ratings by Topic Schema. Values are F-statistics with FDR-adjusted p-values in parentheses.

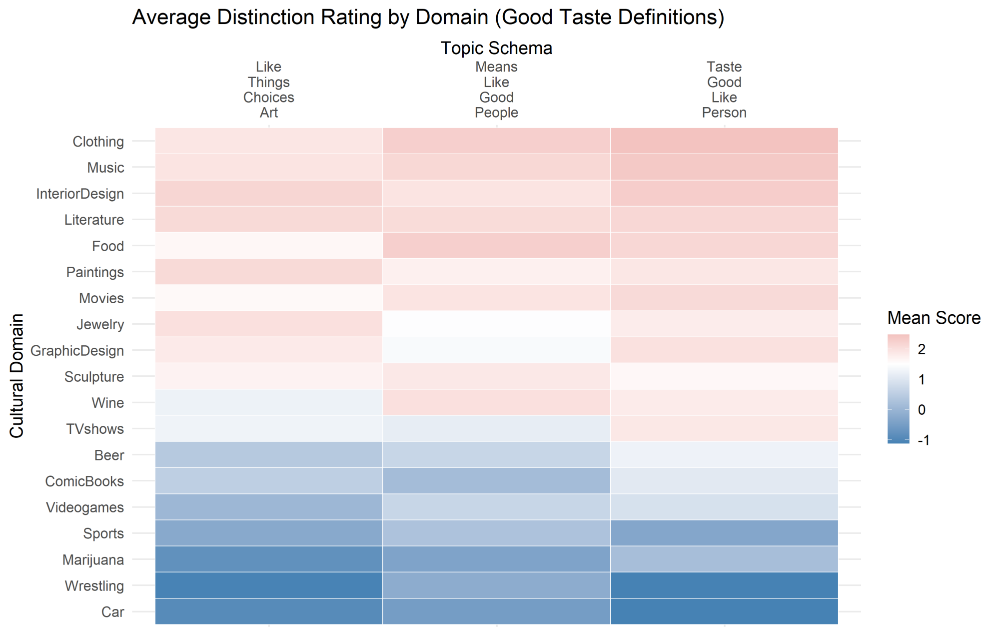


Figure 4: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Schema (Definitions)

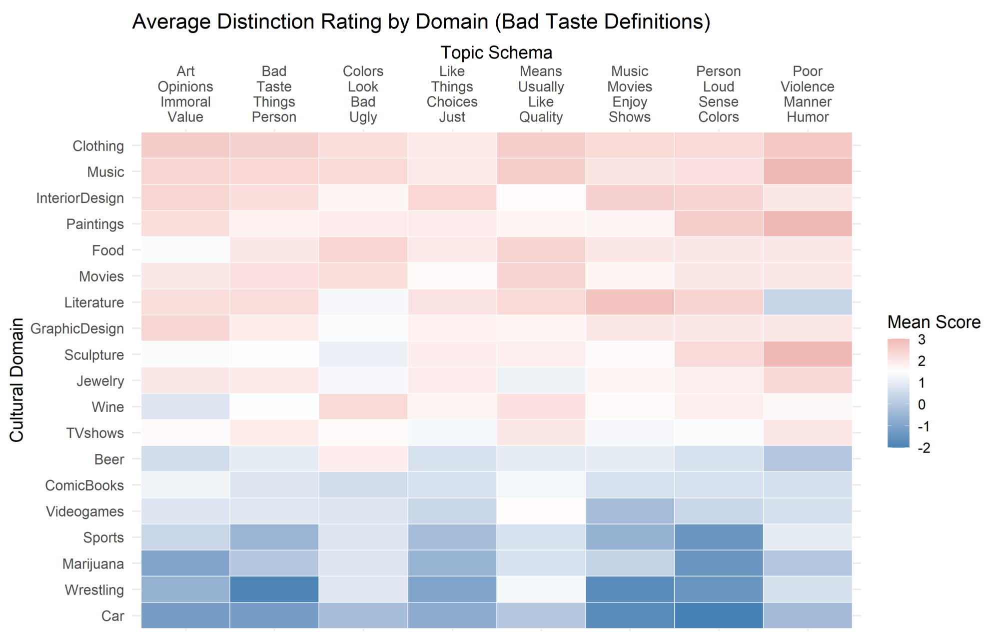


Figure 5: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Schema (Definitions)

5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, homophilous, and moral dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

References

Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA.

Haak, M. v. d. and Wilterdink, N. (2019). Struggling with distinction: How and why people switch between cultural hierarchy and equality. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 22(4):416–432.

Jarness, V. and Friedman, S. (2017). 'i'm not a snob, but...': Class boundaries and the downplaying of difference. *Poetics*, 61:14–25.